Mahatma Gandhi

At its best, the state should not impinge on the consciousness of individuals. People should have the ability to pursue their own values, with complete concentration, for decades on end, without intrusion from the government. One may wish to be a painter, another may wish to be a trader, for each of them there should be the opportunity to be absorbed in the desired zone for decades, without noticing the existence or actions of the state.

Social engineering is inappropriate

This pursuit of non-intrusiveness, stability and order has one powerful implication: We should favour small impacts upon the lives of the people over large ones. Social engineering, even if for ostensibly noble goals, should not be attempted. Every political system has Jacobin elements, which are attracted to transformative projects, that need to be kept in check.

Even if we were comfortable with interfering in the lives of others, large-scale schemes of social engineering have a long track record of failure. Social systems are very complex and outcomes are generally greatly different from those that the planners may have desired. Social engineers have, all too often, ended up inducing a capricious set of upheavals in the lives of the people. There is value in a precautionary principle here: We should be very concerned about initiating a move that will cause harm. For these reasons, even if social engineering were desirable, it is infeasible.

We see social engineering as infeasible and inadvisable, we prefer gradualism. When a government tries to redesign society, to create a new man, this is overreach.

> *If economists could manage to get themselves thought of as humble, competent people on a level with dentists, that would be splendid.*

John Maynard Keynes